BEGINNER'S GUIDE TO BEAUTIFUL HAND EMBROIDERY



Created exclusively for Craftsy
by Kristen Valencia

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Table of Contents

3 Choosing Your Fabric
7 Choosing Your Needles and Floss
10 Choosing Your Hoop
14 Top 10 Must-Know Stitches
25 5 Tips for Uncovering Inspiration
28 Meet the Author

Choosing Your Fabric

Let's talk hand embroidery supplies, zooming in on fabric first. Choosing the right fabric for hand embroidery is a vital part of ensuring your finished piece turns out. Like a canvas is to a painter, the fabric is the foundation for hand embroidery work. It's important to choose a fabric that supports the weight and style of stitches.



Here are some tips on selecting the proper fabric for your next embroidery project!

Each fabric should also be able to hold taut in an embroidery hoop, maintaining the structure of the stitches even after removing the hoop. You want to avoid fabric that might pucker, warp or distort stitches, and make sure that you choose the right fabric that highlights or compliments your stitches, whether you decide to leave the piece in the hoop or frame it with decorative fabric in a quilt piece.

PAY ATTENTION TO THREAD COUNT.

You want to choose fabric with the appropriate thread count and weave that will allow the needle to pull the thread through with ease. Fabrics with a looser weave, such as muslin, cotton, Aida, linen, flour sack, or

Osnaburg are good. These fabrics have a lower thread count than what we might consider as appropriate for bed linens or sheets.

Osnaburg can range anywhere from 40 to 80 thread count, meaning that in one square inch, there are 40 threads widthwise and 40 threads lengthwise to create a thread count of 80. Muslin has a thread count of 150, meaning that it has 75 threads going widthwise and 75 threads going lengthwise to create its weave. Linen thread count can range anywhere from 80 to 150 depending on the manufacturer's style.



CHOOSE COTTON FOR QUILTING

When hand embroidering for a quilt project, you may want to try stitching on Kona Cotton. Because it has a thread count of 120, the weave is easy to pull a needle and thread through.

Again, the looser the weave, the easier the needle can pass through with thread, whereas fabrics with a tighter weave can make it difficult, and even painful on your fingers and hands to pull the needle and thread through.

PRE-WASH TO AVOID PUCKERING.

To avoid puckering, it is a good idea to pre-wash and pre-shrink your fabric prior to stitching. This is especially helpful if you will be incorporating your embroidered piece into a quilt or sewn fabric project.

USE STABILIZER WHEN ADDING ACCENTS

If you are going to be incorporating heavy embroidery with beading, buttons or thick stitching styles, you should use appropriate interfacing or stabilizer as a backing for your fabric. Stitching with fabrics that have stretch in them can be a bit tricky, especially knits, but it is definitely not impossible.



KNOW THE DIFFERENCES BETWEEN FABRICS TO GET THE LOOK YOU WANT.

I have some natural colored muslin and Osnaburg on hand to show you the difference in their weave and how they look with stitches. The muslin is on the left and the Osnaburg is on the right in the above photo. The muslin is lighter with a tighter weave than the Osnaburg, but both are excellent for embroidery.





I personally enjoy stitching on Osnaburg because of the weave and its natural color, which allows me to embellish it with all sorts of brightly colored flosses and stitches. Osnaburg is a medium to heavyweight coarsely woven cotton, shown in the photo above on the left. The weave is a bit loose, making it easy to pull the needle and thread through.

I also enjoy working with muslin, a plain weave cotton with a bit of a tighter weave than Osnaburg, but still great for hand embroidery. Muslin, shown in the photo above on the right, is available in natural unbleached or bleached white.



WHEN IN DOUBT, TRY IT OUT.

It might be a good idea to try a few fabrics to see which you like best, then take off with your stitching from there. I tend to use Osnaburg more than any other fabric appropriate for hand embroidery because that is what I learned on. This may be different for you. The more projects you create and variety of fabrics you try, the more you will intuitively know what fabric will work best for each project.

Choosing Your Needles and Floss

Are you new to hand embroidery and have no idea how to choose the supplies you need to begin? I, too, once stood at the fabric store wondering which needles and thread were appropriate. Don't worry! Here's a quick guide to help you pick the right needles and floss for your stitching adventure.



Needles

Depending on the style of hand embroidery, fabric and floss you'll be using, the right needle will make or break (literally) your design. It is important to choose a good quality needle, the better the needle, the easier and more beautiful it will be for your finished embroidery project. Some of the less expensive or lower quality needles can bend or break as they are being used, which results in a crooked or completely damaged embroidery project.



There are three types of needles usually used for embellishing fabric: embroidery (also referred to as crewel), chenille and tapestry. Shown from left to right in the photo on the left.

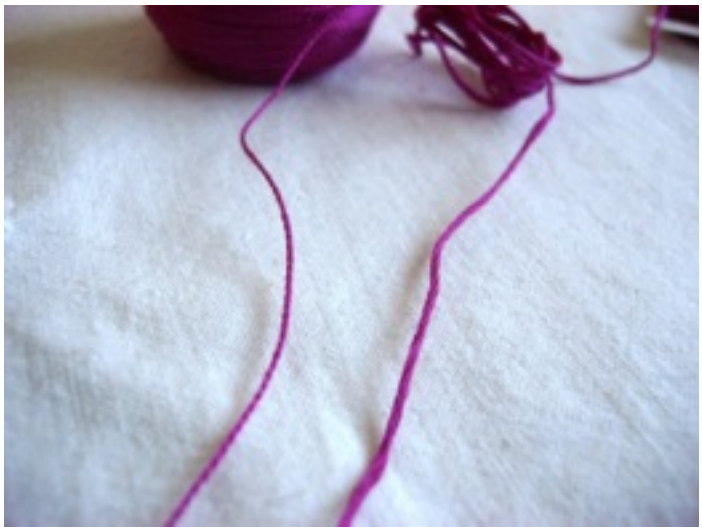
Embroidery needles are the thinner of the three, usually long with a very sharp point in order to move easily through embroidery-appropriate fabric (muslin, cotton, linen or Osnaburg). Embroidery needles usually have a

large enough eye that can easily be threaded with your floss of choice. Chenille needles have sharp points, as well, but have a larger eye and thicker form than embroidery needles. They work well on the same fabrics as embroidery needles. Tapestry needles have a large eye, but a blunt point that works well with canvas work or counted cross-stitch on Aida fabric.

All three needles come in a range of sizes where the higher the number, the thinner or smaller the needle. Depending on the size of floss being used, the correct size needle can be used to create the appropriate stitch and leave a minimum size hole once you move the needle through the fabric.

Floss

Embroidery floss is available in cotton, silk, satin, silk or Pearl (perle) cotton.





The most common floss used for hand embroidery is 6-strand cotton. The strands can be divided according to how fine you want your finished embroidery piece to look. The less strands used, the more fine the finished design will appear.

Pearl cotton, unlike 6-strand cotton floss, cannot be divided. Similar to the sizing for needles, pearl cotton comes in a range of sizes with the higher number making for a thinner or finer size.





If the embroidery design you are creating calls for thin or fine floss, you will want to use a thinner needle in order to ensure a large space or hole is not created as you move the needle through the fabric. For 6-strand or thicker ply floss, you will want to use a larger needle to pull the thread through the fabric accordingly.

When preparing for an embroidery project, I try to make sure to cut the floss the length of my forearm (from my fingertips to my elbow). This prevents twisting or knotting of the floss as I stitch. If the floss becomes fluffy or dull looking, I recommend switching to a fresh piece of floss.

I recommend testing out needles and floss size before beginning an embroidery project. This allows you to get a feel for the needle as you work, and allows you to see which floss ply works best for your project. I always find its best to experiment in order to determine which supplies work best.

Choosing Your Hoop

When it comes to hand needlework, there's a common question that always seems to arise: What sort of hoop should you use? Embroidery hoops come in a range of sizes and are available in wood, plastic or metal. Some hoops are round, square or oval, while others are large rectangles or scrolls. Hoops are a necessary tool for hand embroidery, so choosing the right hoop for your intended work is important for both personal comfort as you embroider as well as the quality of your finished stitches.

Here are a few tips and recommendations to help you choose the right hand embroidery hoop.



Hoop sizes

Embroidery hoops come in two pieces: the outer edge or framing piece with spring or screw hardware and a piece that fits inside of it. Round hoops, the most common shape hoop, range in size from 3 to 14-inches in diameter, but these size proportions are similar to other shape hoops.

The size of the hoop to use depends on the size of your project. The hoop should fit around your fabric with some overhang. The fabric should lay taut within the hoop. But it should not be so tight that it causes the fabric to pucker after your run the floss through the fabric.

It is best to choose a hoop that fits comfortably in one hand, while you stitch with the other. The hoop does not necessarily have to frame the embroidery pattern, it can be larger or smaller, but I recommend removing the hoop from the project when it is not being worked on, in order to avoid indenting the fabric with the hoop.



Material: wooden vs. plastic

Embroidery hoops made out of wood or bamboo have a smooth inner hoop. It is common for embroiderers to wrap the inner layer of the wooden hoop with twill tape in order to create a more snug fit for the fabric. Although, this is not a necessary step, it is the preference of the embroiderer whether or not they choose to wrap the inner hoop.

If you choose wooden hoops for your project, make sure to purchase a quality hoop. While I prefer using wooden embroidery hoops, it has happened, on occasion, that the inside hoop cracked while I was stitching.





Plastic embroidery hoops often have a groove or lip on the inside where the inner hoop locks into the outer hoop, in addition to having the screw hardware to tighten the hoops together. This makes for a snug fit and allows the fabric to be held taut for hand embroidery projects.

Metal embroidery hoops are not as commonly available as wooden or plastic hoops. I frequently encounter metal embroidery hoops as vintage items and have yet to see one at the local fabric or craft store.

Hoop shapes

While it is more common to find round hoops at fabric and craft stores, there are also square and oval shaped embroidery hoops. As with embroidery hoop size, the shape depends on the embroidery project. I have only recently seen a rise in use of scroll and Tambour embroidery frames among my embroidery friends and colleagues. The scroll frames work much like the name sounds: The fabric is wrapped around two wooden dowels and stretched a bit to make the fabric taut. Tambour embroidery frames clamp the four edges of the fabric keeping it taut.

Embroidery hoops vs. quilting hoops

There are some hoops used for hand quilting that I have seen embroiderers use for needlework projects. Quilting hoops are larger than embroidery hoops and can support thicker fabrics.

A square hoop or Q-Snap frame, often used for hand quilting, is made out of PVC and has outer clips that fit snuggly around each of the four edges of the project, leaving the corners exposed. It works just as well for hand quilting as it does for embroidery.



While there are quite a few options to choose from when it comes to embroidery hoops, it all depends on what you feel most comfortable with.

Try a few out and see which one you like best!

Top 10 Must-Know Stitches

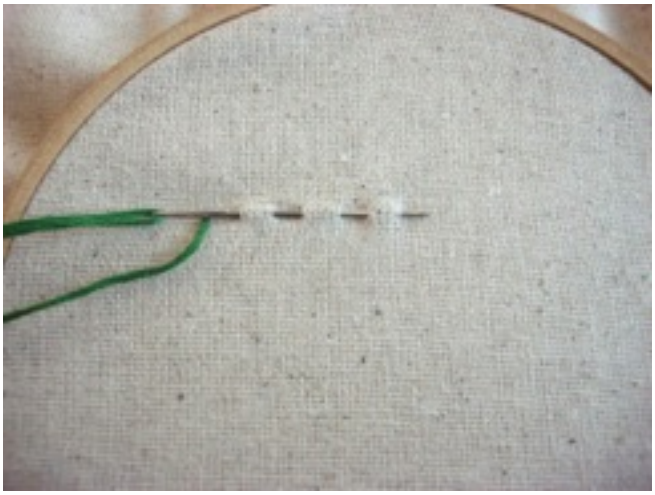
If you have ever browsed through an embroidery book, especially the vintage variety, it can be a little overwhelming when trying to make sense of the different types of stitches the patterns might require. Some of the stitches may seem too challenging or perhaps laborious, but fear not, hand embroidery stitches are fun, and with practice, can become quite easy.

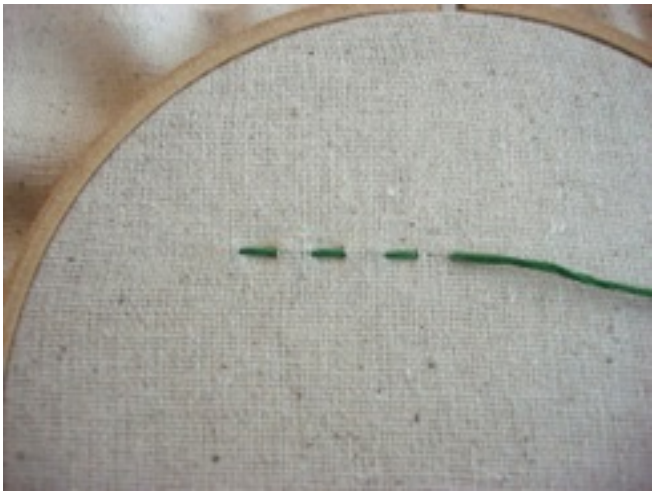


Once you familiarize yourself with basic stitches, you will find that they are the foundation to those more elaborate stitches that once seemed too difficult to tackle. Here are ten embroidery stitches to know as you move forward with hand embroidery.

1. Running stitch

The running stitch is good for outlining an embroidery design and is a very quick stitch to do. There are two ways to do the running stitch: the first method is similar to hand sewing and can be completed by pushing



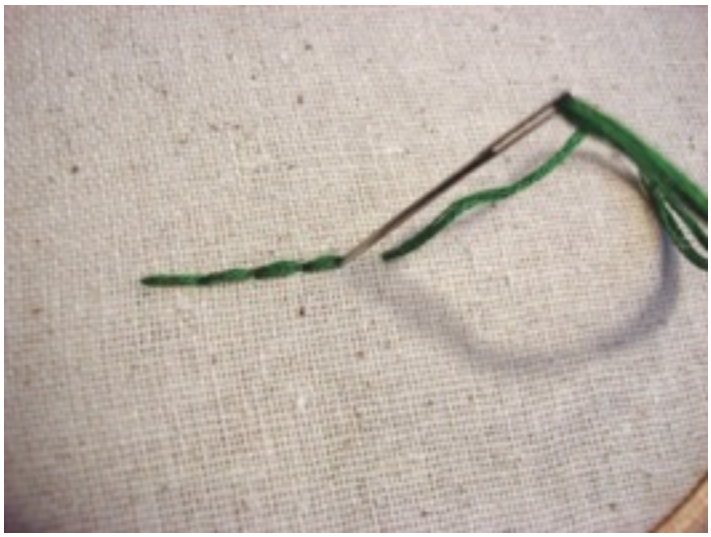


the needle and floss in and over the fabric in one continuous motion; the second method can be literally pushing the needle through the fabric and pulling it back up. I have heard this called the "punch and poke" or "stabbing" method.

2. Backstitch

Unlike the running stitch, the backstitch creates a solid line and is good for hand embroidering text or outlining a design.



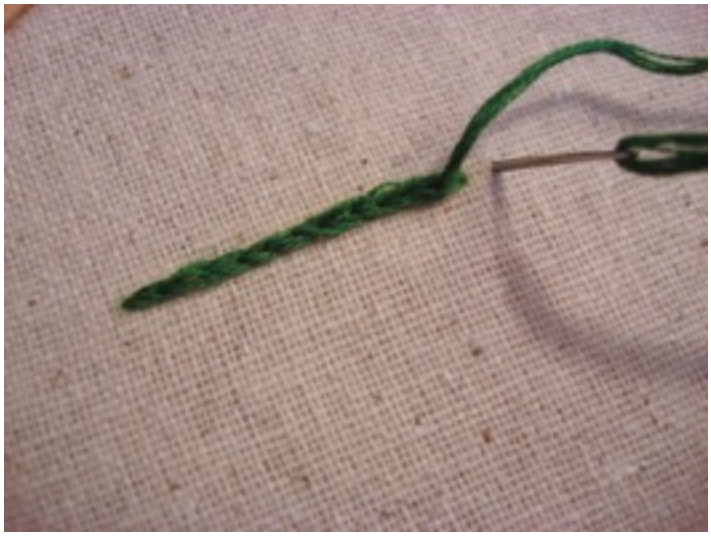


Begin by pulling the needle and floss up through the fabric and do one stitch forward. From underneath, space the needle out the length of your desired stitch, pull up through the fabric, and bring the needle and floss back down through the end of the previous stitch.

3. Split stitch

Similar to the backstitch, the split stitch creates a solid line with an added texture to it. This stitch is appropriate for text and outline as well, but it also works to fill designs and create variation from the running or backstitch.



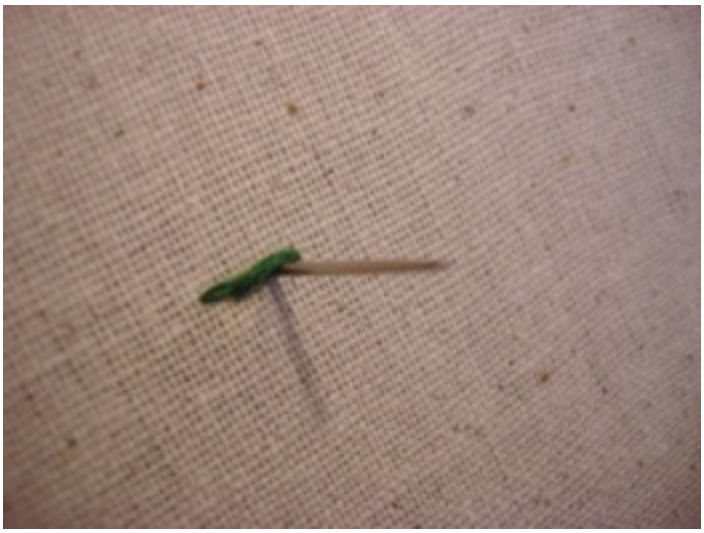


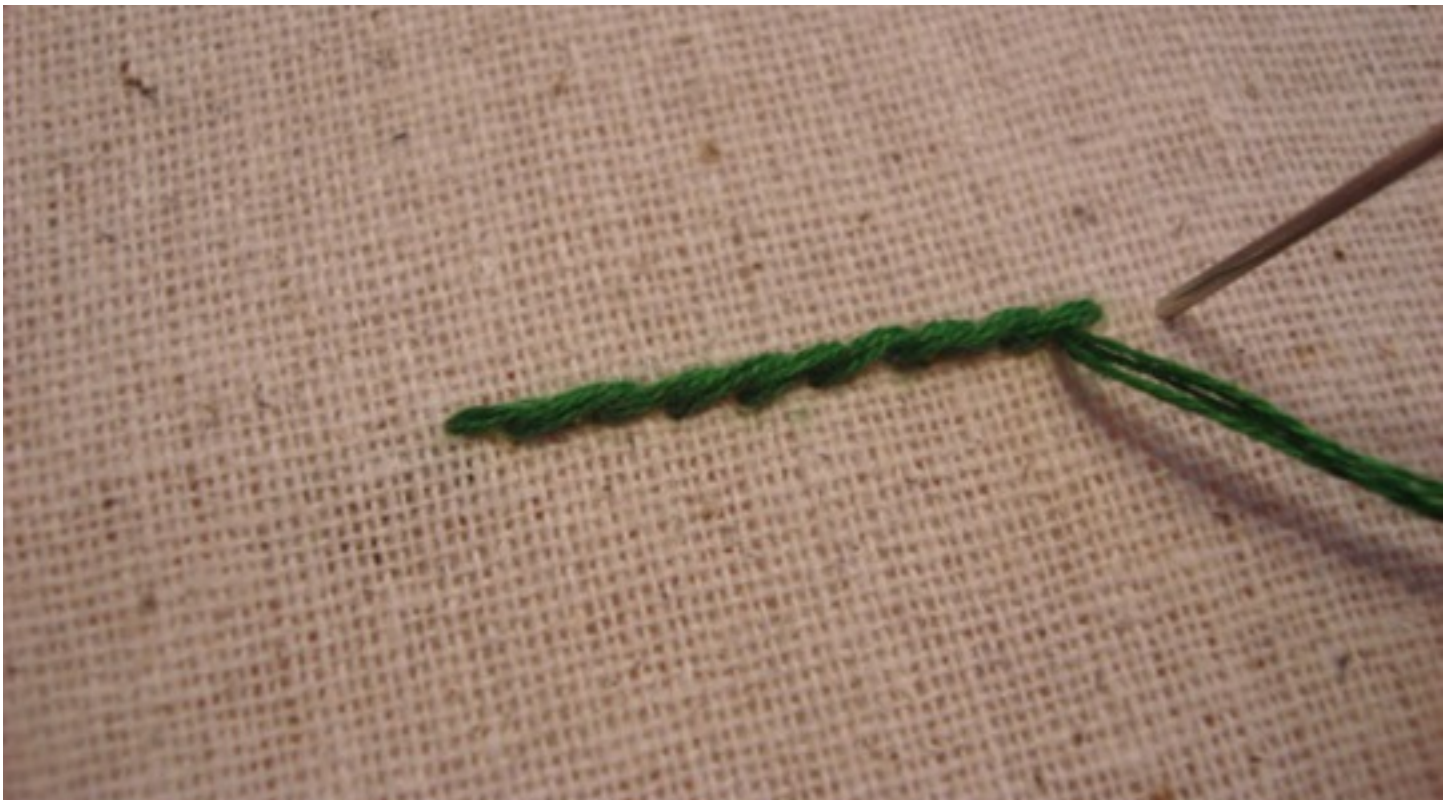
To begin, pull your needle and floss up through the fabric and create one straight stitch. Your needle and floss should be on the underside of your hoop. Bring the needle up through the center of the stitch you just created and stitch forward the same length as your initial stitch. Repeat by bringing the needle up through the center of each stitch.

4. Stem stitch

The stem stitch got its name from being the common stitch used for the stems of flowers or vines. I like to use this stitch for text because it can curve nicely with letters. Similar to the split stitch, you create one straight stitch forward and bring the needle and floss up underneath the fabric, but instead of going through the center of this initial stitch, you will bring the needle up just to the side of the stitch.

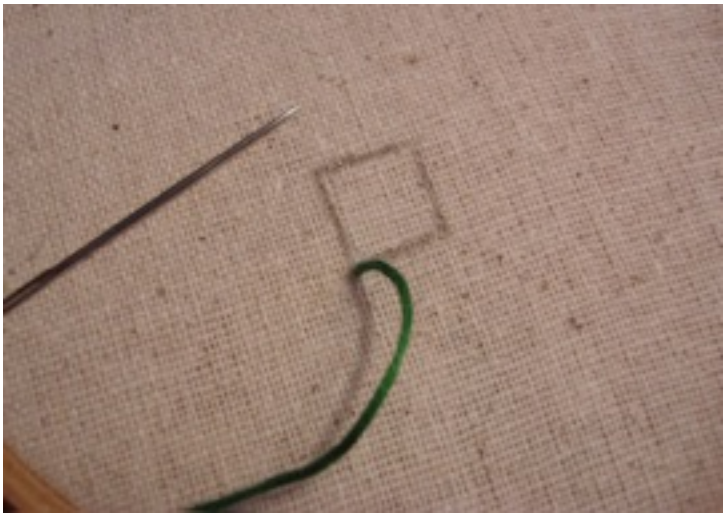


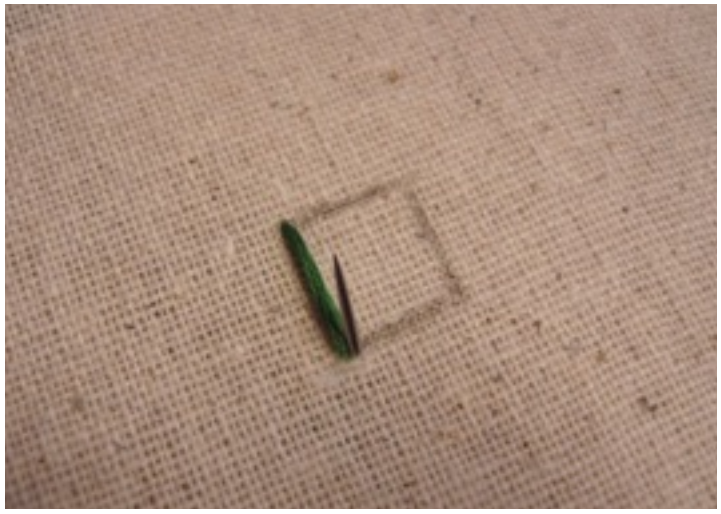


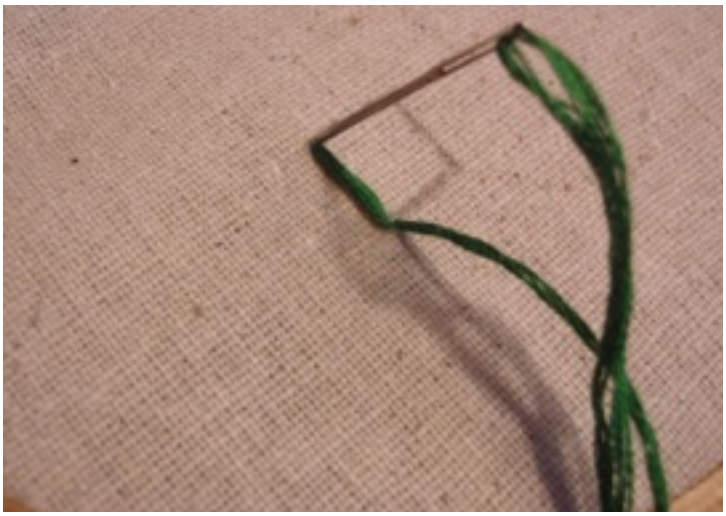


5. Satin stitch

A good filler stitch, the satin stitch creates a smooth appearance. I like to use this stitch to fill in hearts or the leaves of flowers.

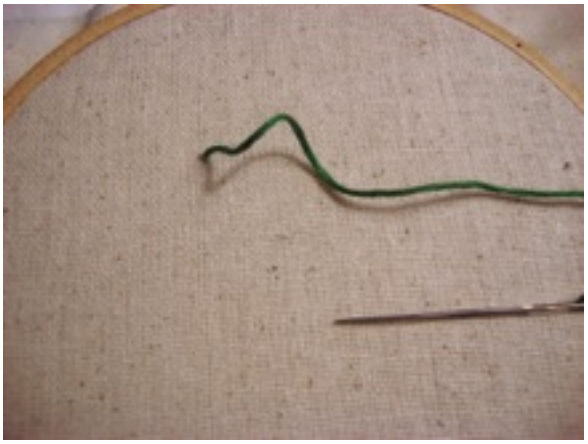








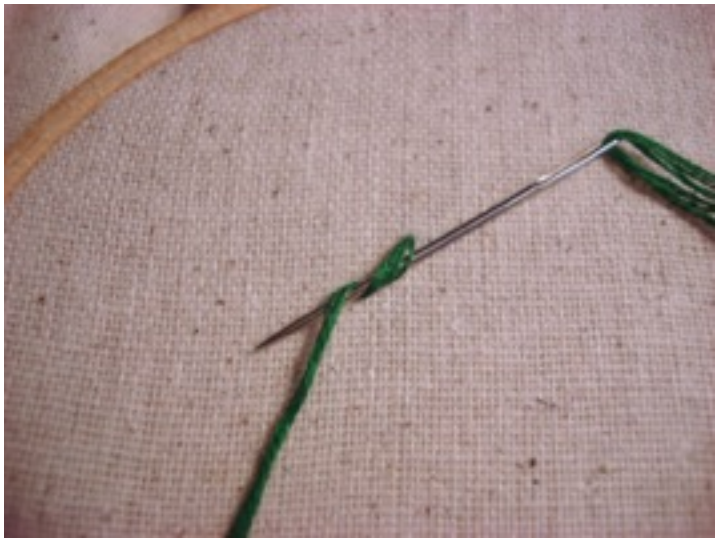
Take your needle and floss and create one stitch. Bring the needle up again just next to the opposite side of the initial stitch. Keep the stitches close to one another, as required to fill the pattern or design you are working with.



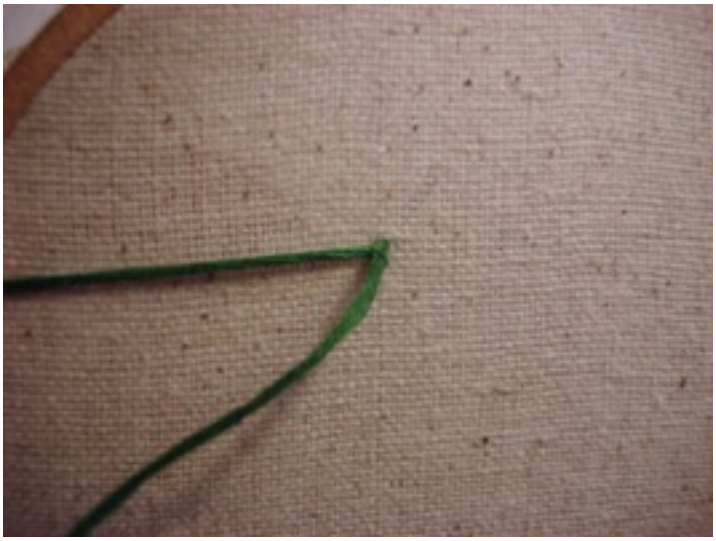
6. French knots

This is a favorite decorative stitch for almost everyone that I know. French knots can be used to accent designs or create fun fillers for most designs.

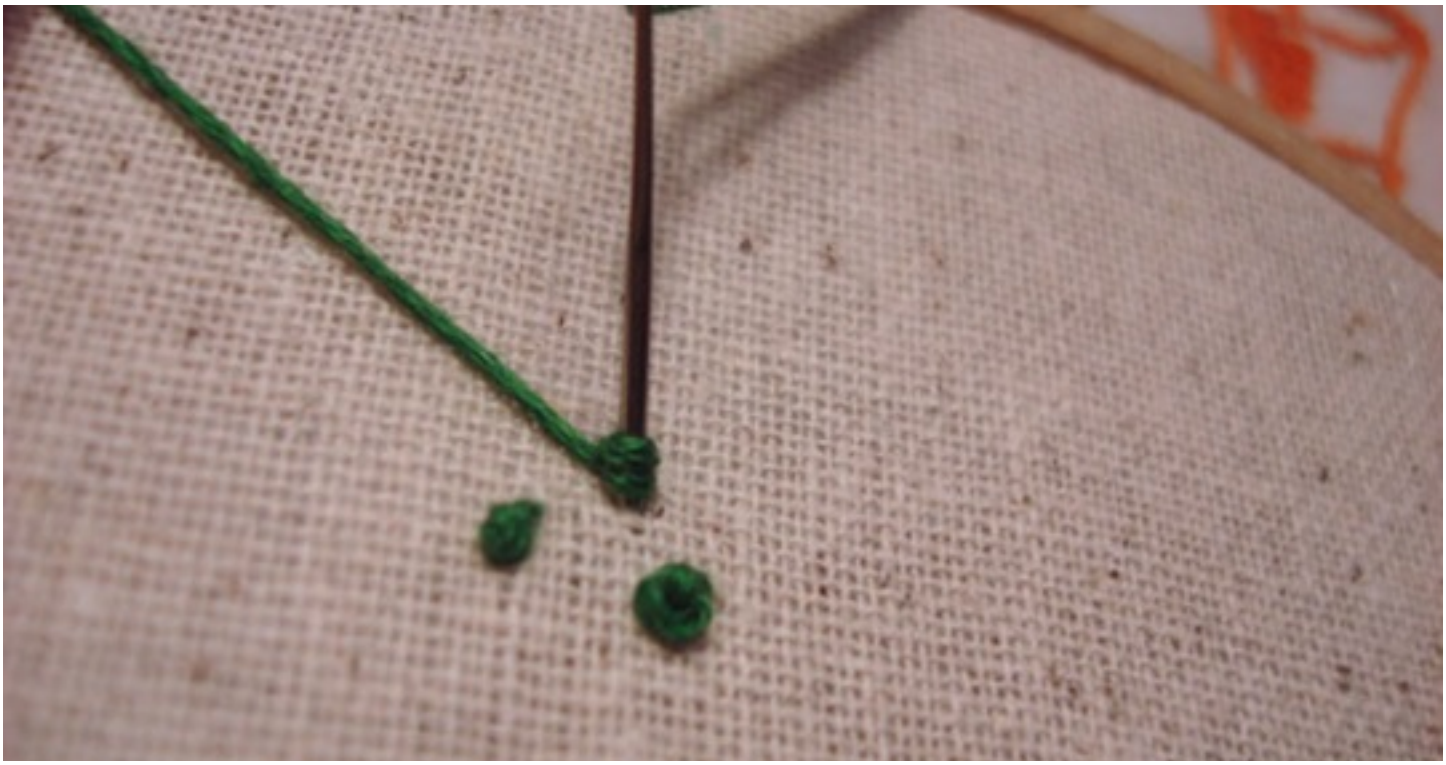
You'll have to use two hands to create the French knot by bringing the needle and floss up through the fabric and wrapping the floss around the needle twice. Hold the end of the floss taut and bring the needle down just next to the space where it came out through. Keep holding the floss taut as you pull the needle through. You can vary the size of your French knots by wrapping the floss around the needle anywhere between one and three times.

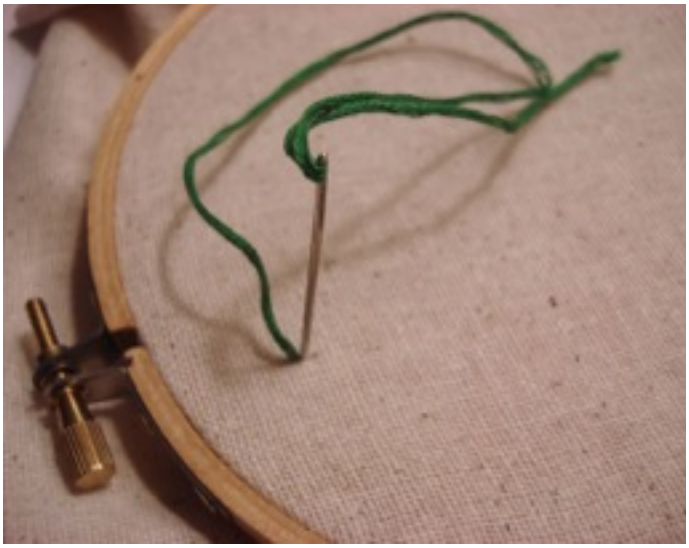


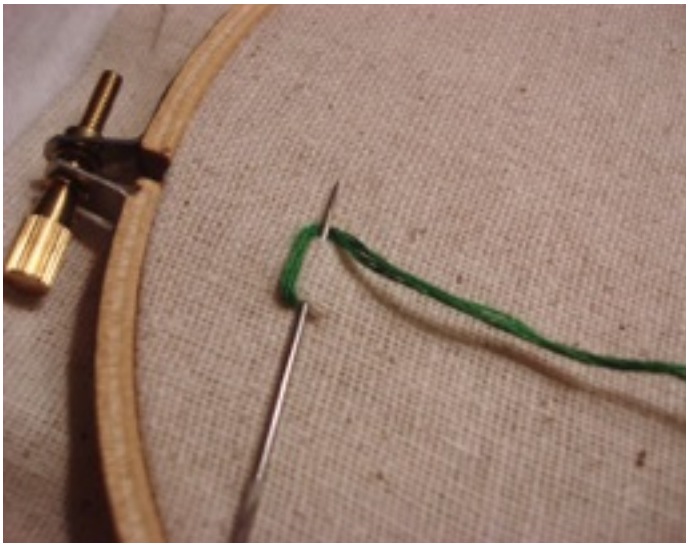










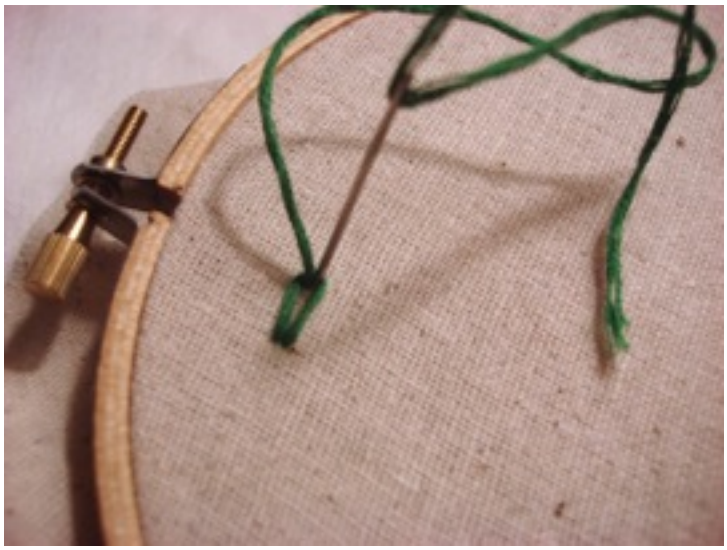


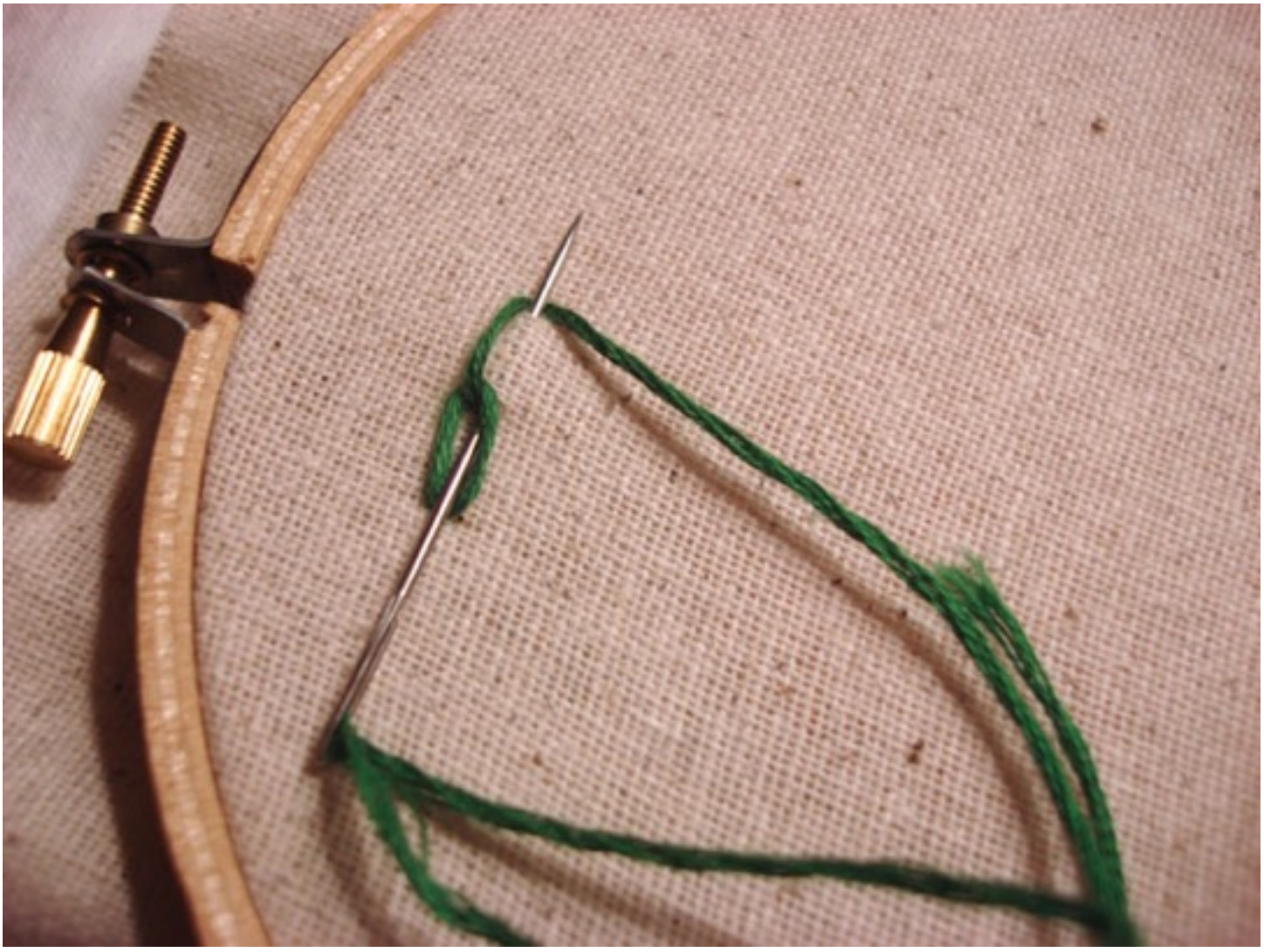
7. Chain stitch

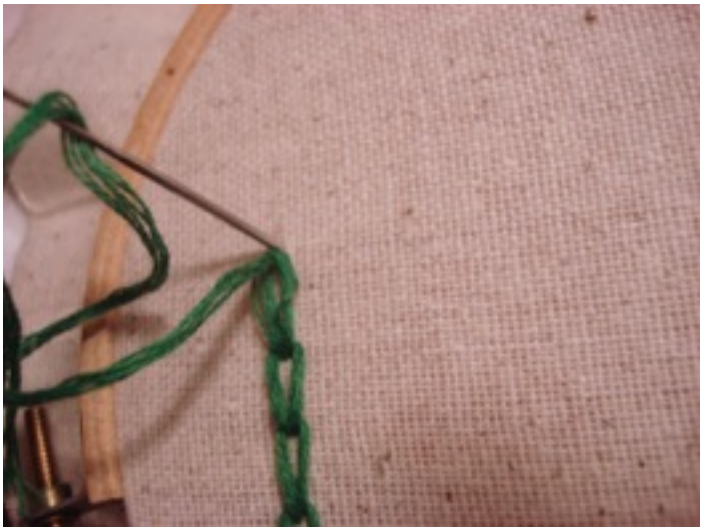
I used to think I would never learn to do this stitch, then I tried it, and now I love using the chain stitch. It makes for a great outline stitch as well as a frame for a pattern or design.

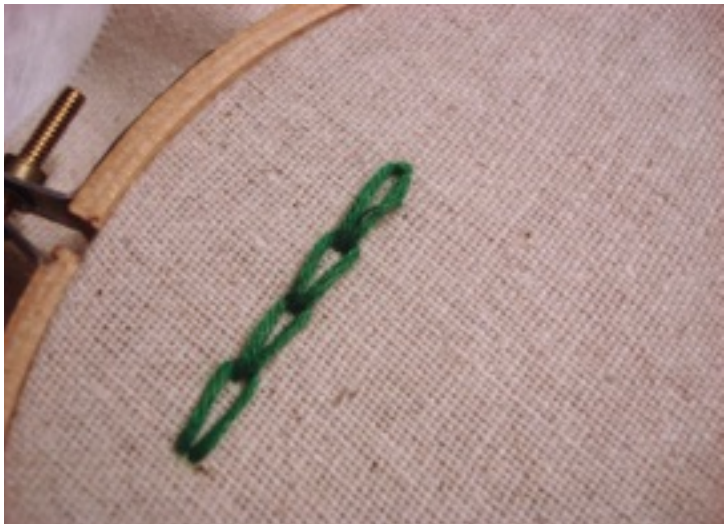
Take your needle and floss and create a stitch, but before you pull the floss all the way through the fabric, allow it to form a loop. Bring the needle up through that loop in order to tether it from being pulled all the way through the fabric and pull. Place the needle either directly in the hole you just stitched, or close to it, and pull through creating another loop by not pulling the floss completely through the fabric. Pull the needle up through the loop to tether it and pull. Repeat the steps to continue the chain. When you reach the end of the chain, simply create a small stitch over the loop.





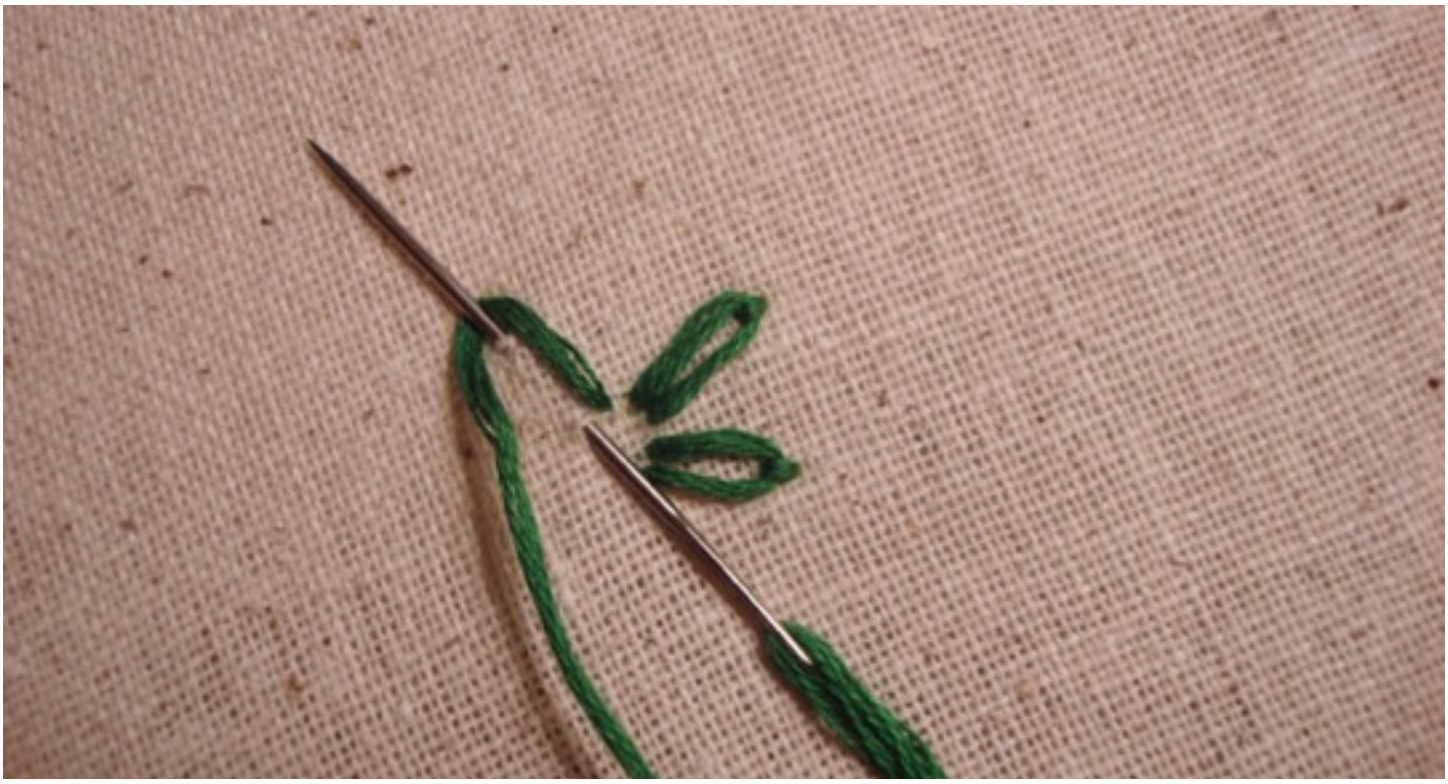






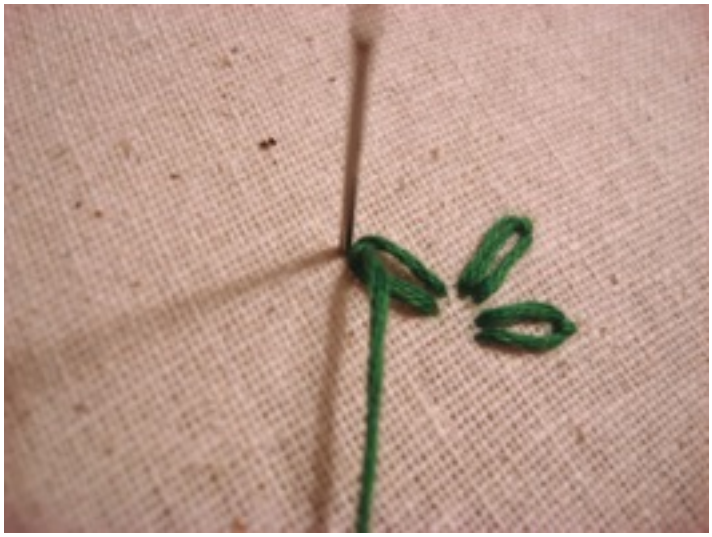
8. Lazy daisy

This is a version of the chain stitch often referred to as the “detached chain stitch” or “lazy daisy.” Instead of continuing the chain, there is a small stitch made just over the end of the loop to create what looks like a daisy petal.



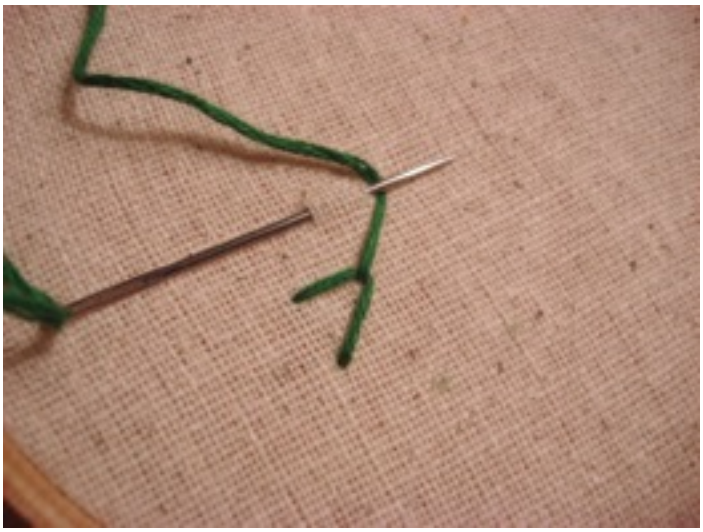
Just like the chain stitch, take your needle and floss and create a stitch, but before you pull the floss all the way through the fabric, allow it to form a loop. Bring the needle up through that loop in order to tether it from being pulled all the way through the fabric and create a small stitch over the top of the loop. Space out the next loop or use the stitch to create a daisy.





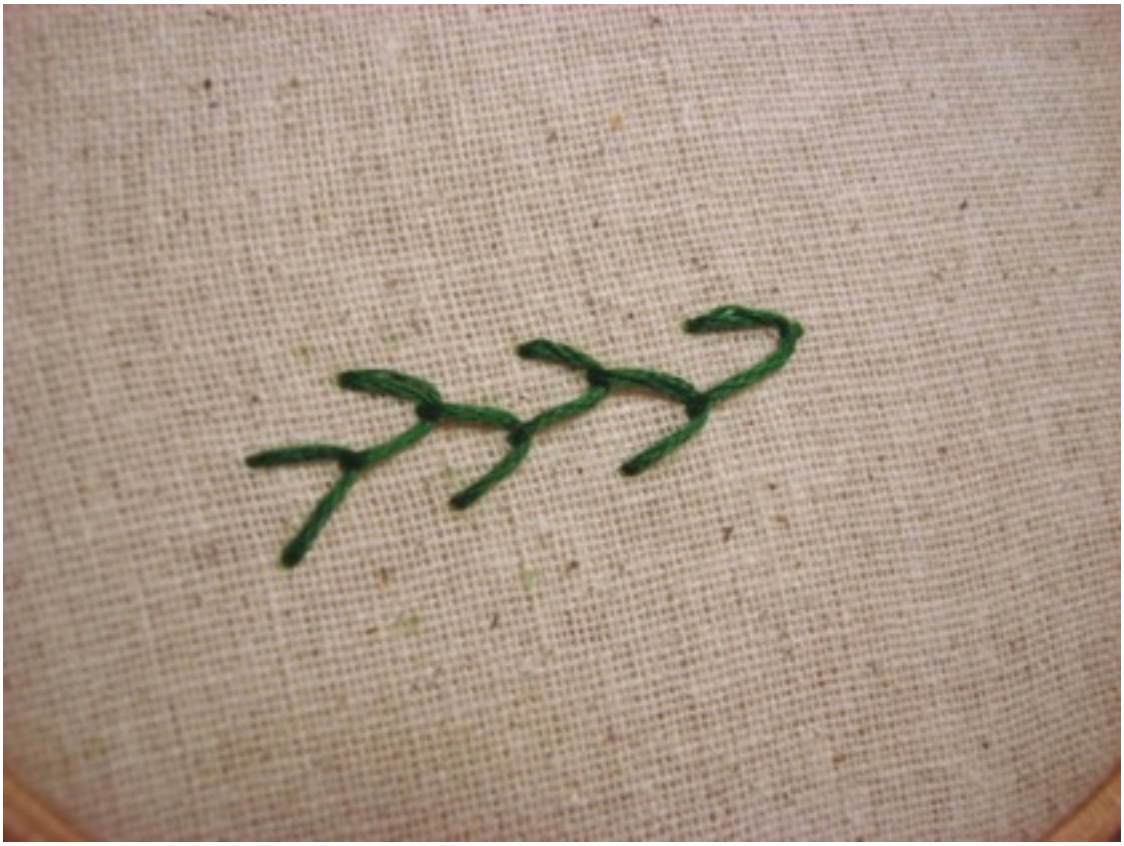
9. Feather stitch

Another variation of a chain stitch is the feather stitch. This stitch looks great as a frame or border to an embroidered piece.



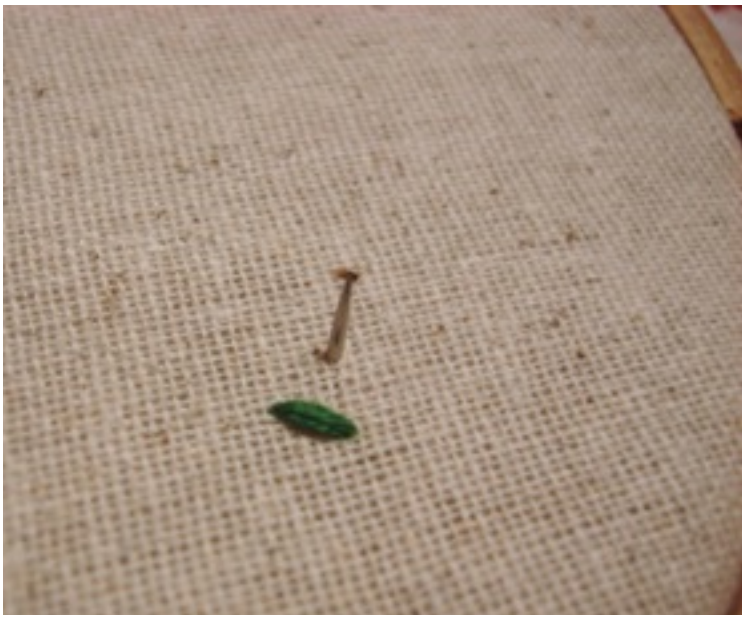


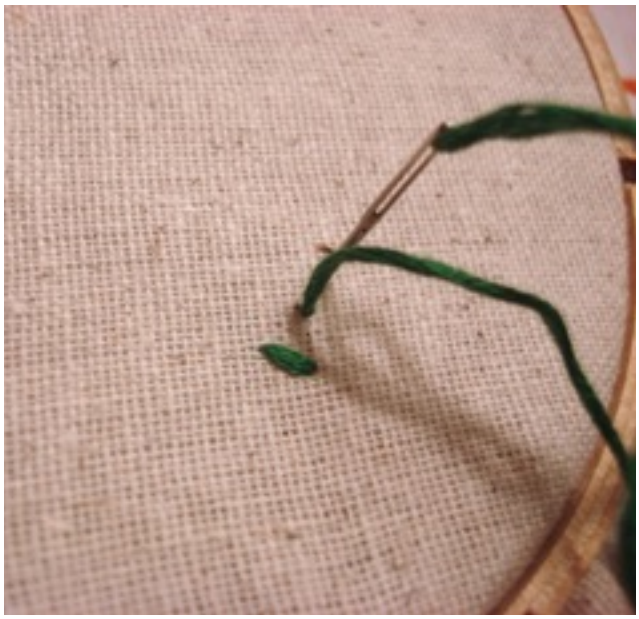
Similar to the chain stitch, you will use the second stitch to anchor the loop of the previous stitch, but this stitch covers more space. Bring the needle and floss up through the fabric and create a straight stitch, but don't pull the floss all the way through. Allow a loop to form and bring the needle up through that loop. Space the next stitch over in the opposite direction from the previous stitch. Create another loop by not allowing the floss to go completely through the fabric. Pull the needle up through the loop and repeat on the opposite side



10. Seed stitch

This is a good filler stitch. Depending how close or far you space out your seed stitch, you can create a wide fill or layers of floss that appear to have dimension.

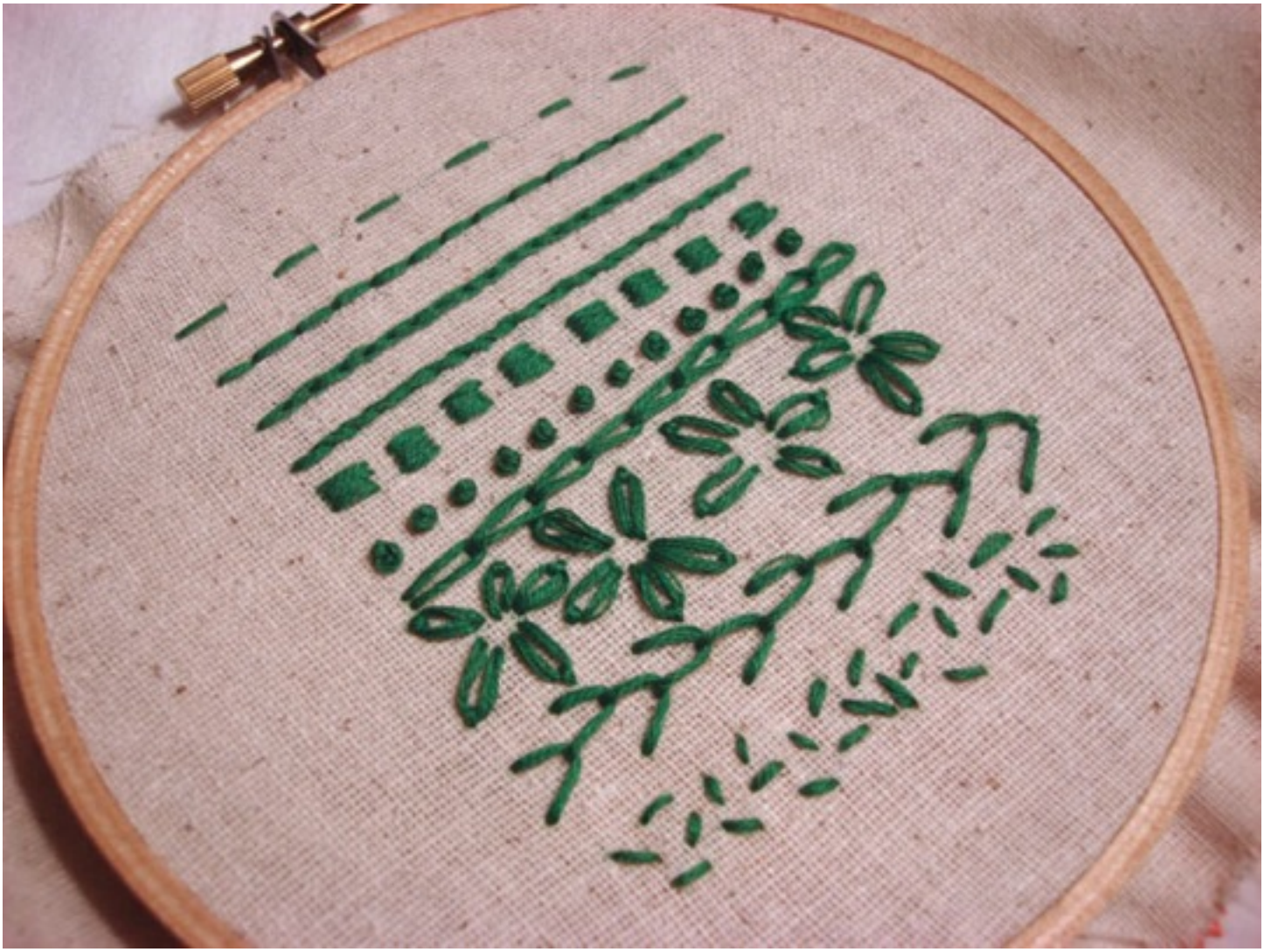




Imagine tossing the contents of a seed packet into the air and watching the seeds fall randomly on the ground. That same concept applies here. Bring the needle and floss up through the fabric and create a straight stitch. Bring the needle and floss up through the fabric again in a different angle. Continue until you have a filled area.



These stitches in no way comprise the totality of gorgeous hand embroidery stitches that exist, but they are exactly what you need to get you started. If you are already a seasoned embroiderer, maybe these will remind you to revisit those old tried and true stitches you may not have used in a while. I had forgotten how much the chain stitch used to intimidate me, but now, I'm so glad I tried it because it really is a fun stitch.



5 Tips
for Uncovering Inspiration

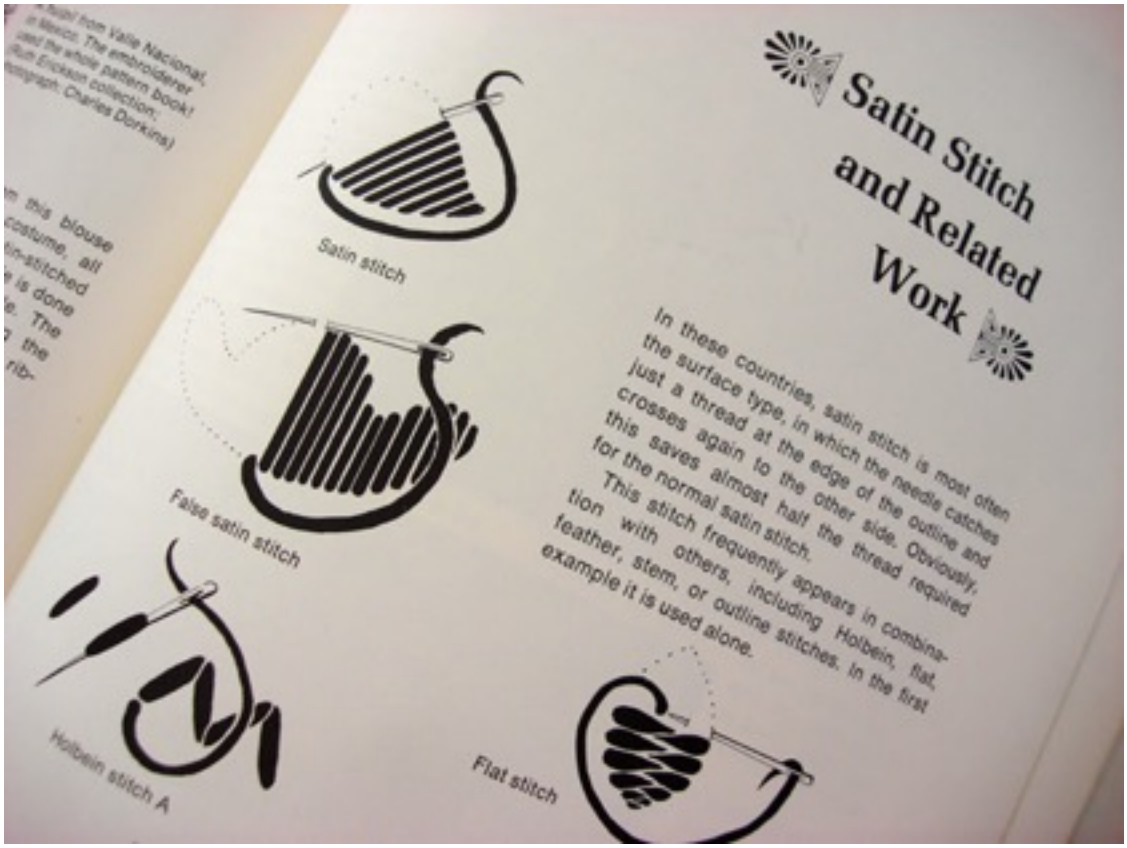
We live during a particularly lucky moment in time where all things handmade are becoming more and more valued over anything mass manufactured. Hand embroidery has risen in popularity as a means for delivering this handmade goodness. No longer just for tea towels or pillows, hand embroidery has been used to perk up anything from sneakers and button-down shirts, to cell phone covers and jewelry. Because it's very easy on the pocket, it's great for threading a handmade touch into what we wear, carry and decorate our homes with. But before we get started, we need inspiration! Here are 5 ways to tap into the inspiration all around you to bring beautiful hand embroidery to life!



Hit the books to learn a new stitch.

Rekindle your stitching fire by trying out a new stitch to keep yourself interested and inspired. Your local library, used book sales and online shopping can help you find the innovative techniques you need to keep

your stitching fresh. I recently found a book all about Mexican embroidery at the local library, and learned a stitch I wasn't familiar with: the false satin stitch. After a couple tries, I figured it out and now I'm incorporating it everywhere.



Explore yard sales and thrift stores for patterned items and vintage textiles.

When it comes to embroidery, everyone has something different that tugs at their heartstrings. Personally, I take a lot away from antique textiles and vintage pieces. I feel that I can take a traditional technique and update it a bit for a more contemporary use. I found a vintage tablecloth for $6.00 at a local thrift store, and I keep it draped over the table in my workspace to encourage my embroidery work. You can also refer to different patterns on fabrics, clothes and home decor to light a new spark in your next embroidery design.

3. Let illustrations and art kickstart your imagination.

Flip through children's books, whether they're your favorites from when you were young or just something you find at a used book sale. Or explore art websites like Craftsy, Society6 and Etsy to see the works of brilliant illustrators and artists.

The best part about the creative process is that we allow our minds to wander organically, dreaming up the next project we want to complete. This is an excellent practice in taking ideas to finished artistic pieces. If you can dream it, you can make it!





Explore others' projects online andcollect what you love.

Jump online and instantly access inspiration through Craftsy's projects section, pattern shop or embroidery blogs, and keep track of what you love! I have found that the adage about collecting antiques, "Surround yourself with the things you love most in life," applies not only to home decor, but to embroidery, as well. Take a little time to organize the ideas that inspire you the most and run with them.

Use bookmarking sites like Pinterest, Delicious, or your own Tumblr to store of all the beautiful inspiration you find so that you can revisit it when you're ready to begin your next work of art.

Discover new techniques with convenient online classes.

If you can dream it, it can be done — you just need the skills! Learn how to hand embroider over 25 types of stitches with decorative flair when you join Jessica Marquez's *Design It, Stitch It: Hand Embroidery* class. Or explore all of Craftsy's online hand embroidery classes to get all the tips and tricks you need to begin stitching away!

Meet the Author



KRISTEN VALENCIA

Kristen is a self-taught embroiderer with over 10 years of stitching experience. Her passion for bright and colorful stitches comes from the hand-embroidered Mexican blouses she encountered on a trip to Mexico City many years ago. She returned to her home in Southern Arizona and took up embroidery, learning stitching techniques from books found at flea markets and vintage stores. As a child, her grandmother taught her how to sew, and today, Kristen combines those sewing skills and stitching work, creating new and different places to infuse embroidery into every area of her world.